Case Study: Phishing

Phishing is a type of cybercrime in which attackers impersonate a trusted organization to trick individuals into revealing sensitive information such as passwords, bank details, or personal data. These attacks commonly occur through emails, messages, or fake websites designed to appear legitimate.

Let us consider a very common case: a middle-aged woman, Neeti, receives an email claiming to be from her bank, asking for her account details and password. The email includes a professional logo, formal and urgent language, urging her to act immediately, otherwise her account will be suspended. A link directs her to a website that looks like the official bank website, asking for her to input details.

Neeti, unsuspecting and afraid, acts without thinking. She puts in her details without verifying with anyone from the bank, trusting the email blindly. Within a few hours, she receives numerous alerts from her bank, saying that lakhs and lakhs of rupees have been withdrawn, all without her consent. When she finally calls the bank, it turns out that all her money has been stolen. The attacker had gained access to her account and robbed all her money.

The attack followed a typical pattern. First, the attacker created a sense of urgency to prevent Neeti from thinking critically. Next, the link redirected Neeti to a fake website that closely resembled the official bank page. Trusting the message, she had submitted the form.

This is a very common case that occurs, all over the world, every single day. Not just housewives, vulnerable people from every walk of life- students, job seekers, individuals unfamiliar with cybersecurity practices- all are potential victims of phishing unless they look out for it. They exploit curiosity, urgency, and lack of verification. The consequences can include identity theft, financial loss, account hacking, and long-term misuse of personal data.